DBQ Sourcing 5C: Point of View

Oct 28, 2026 · @CJ DeRuyter

What point of view means

Point of view is *who the author is* — their role, identity, experience, and stake — and how that position shapes what they say. It is **not** the author's opinion. "The point of view of Document 1 is that the railroad is good for the country" is College Board's own non-example: that's content.

How it feeds Purpose: who someone is determines what they want. A former general frames everything as security; an abolitionist minister reaches for scripture; a Republican congresswoman in 1976 wants a smaller government. Name the identity, and the purpose follows (see 5D).

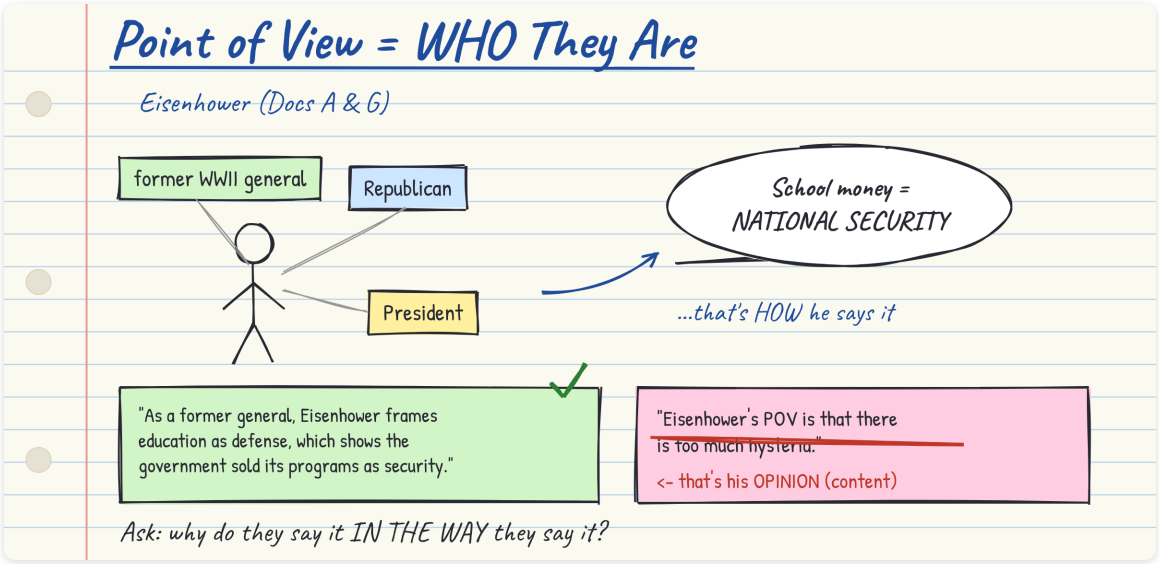
To earn credit, a point-of-view explanation must:

1. **Identify the author's position**: job, party, race, gender, religion, region, or experience.
2. **Explain how that position shapes the document**: why someone like this would say this.
3. **Connect it to the argument**: what the perspective reveals about the prompt.

The common failure is a POV sentence that just repeats the source line ("Eisenhower was the president") or the document's claim. The test: does the sentence explain *why* this person would say this?

The formula

> "As a [specific identity / role], [author] [believed / had reason to] [stake]. This explains why [he/she] [says content], which shows [argument]."



1. **Read the source line for identity clues**: title, party, publication, organization, date.
2. **Add what you know**: party, past career, causes they championed.

3. **Use "As a…"**: the phrase forces an identity, not an opinion.
4. **Explain the stake**: what this person gained, feared, or believed because of who they were.
5. **Tie to the thesis.**

Cold War DBQ points of view (written for this guide):

Doc	Author	Point of view worth explaining
A	Eisenhower	Republican president and former WWII commander; same party as McCarthy, so his criticism of "unwise investigators" is notable.
B	Dulles	Secretary of State and leading hard-line anticommunist; architect of the administration's foreign policy.
E	Kennedy	Democrat who campaigned in 1960 on a "missile gap" and a tougher Cold War stance.
F	Herblock	Washington Post cartoonist, a liberal critic of the administration who coined the word "McCarthyism."
G	Eisenhower	Former general who consistently framed domestic spending as national defense.

Examples that earned credit

Source	Document	What was credited
2023 Set 1, Sample 1A (score 7)	Doc 7	Frederick Douglass's point of view as a famous African American abolitionist.
2023 Set 2, Sample 1A (score 7)	Doc 5	Du Bois as an activist who “wanted African Americans to further their scope of rights.”
2023 Set 2, Sample 1B (score 5)	Doc 5	“DuBois was an advocate for Civil Rights and worked to empower and encourage African Americans.”
2024 Set 1, Sample 1A (score 7)	Doc 6	An abolitionist minister using biblical justification to condemn slavery.

College Board model sentences:

> “As a formerly enslaved woman, Parsons understood how a small economic elite could dominate a larger group of laborers to its benefit, and therefore, she is seeking to take action to unite middle- and working-class Americans against the growing strength of monopolies.” (2025 Set 2, Doc 3)
>
> “Banneker's perspective as a free African American, through his appeal to American Revolutionary ideology, showed that African Americans personally understood the contradiction between the nation's founding ideals and the persistence of slavery…” (2024 Set 1, Doc 2)

Note how the Parsons example moves from identity (POV) straight into what she is "seeking" (purpose). That's the HIPP chain in one sentence.

Cold War model (written for this guide):

> "As a Republican president and former general, Eisenhower in Document A had every reason to look tough on communism, yet he warns that 'unwise investigators' are creating 'hysteria.' Coming from someone in McCarthy's own party, this shows that by 1954 even government leaders believed the anticommunist crusade was making fear worse."

Examples that did not earn credit

Source	Attempt	Why it fails
2024 Set 1, Sample 1B (score 6)	Point of view for Doc 2 (Banneker)	"Simply repeats information that is specified in the document." Restating the source line isn't explaining it.
2025 guidelines (non-example)	"The point of view of Document 1 is that the railroad is good for the country."	That's the document's claim (content), not the author's position.
2024 guidelines (non-example)	"In Document 4 the minister said that slavery was fine with him."	Summarizes the content; never explains how being a minister matters.

Cold War non-examples (written for this guide):

- "Eisenhower's point of view is that there is too much hysteria." Opinion, not identity.
- "Document B is from John Foster Dulles, the Secretary of State." Copies the source line; no "so what."
- "Herblock was biased." Biased how, and why? Bias claims need the identity and its effect.

Expert tips (Heimler's History)

Heimler's test question for point of view: **"Why does he or she say what he or she says *in the way that he or she says it*?"** The "special sauce," he says, is the last part, *in the way they say it* (THREE Secrets, 2024).

That's a useful classroom check: a POV sentence should explain the author's *tone or framing* through their identity. For example, Eisenhower the general frames school funding as "national security" (Doc G); Kennedy the new president pairs threats with an offer of peace (Doc E).

Grader checklist

1. Does the sentence describe who the author *is* (role, identity, experience), not what the document says?
2. Does it go beyond copying the source line?
3. Does it explain how that position shaped the document's message?
4. Is it tied to an argument about the prompt?

Four yeses = this document counts toward the two needed.

Feedback stem: "You described what [author] said, which is content. For point of view, start with 'As a [role/identity]…' and explain why someone in that position would say this."